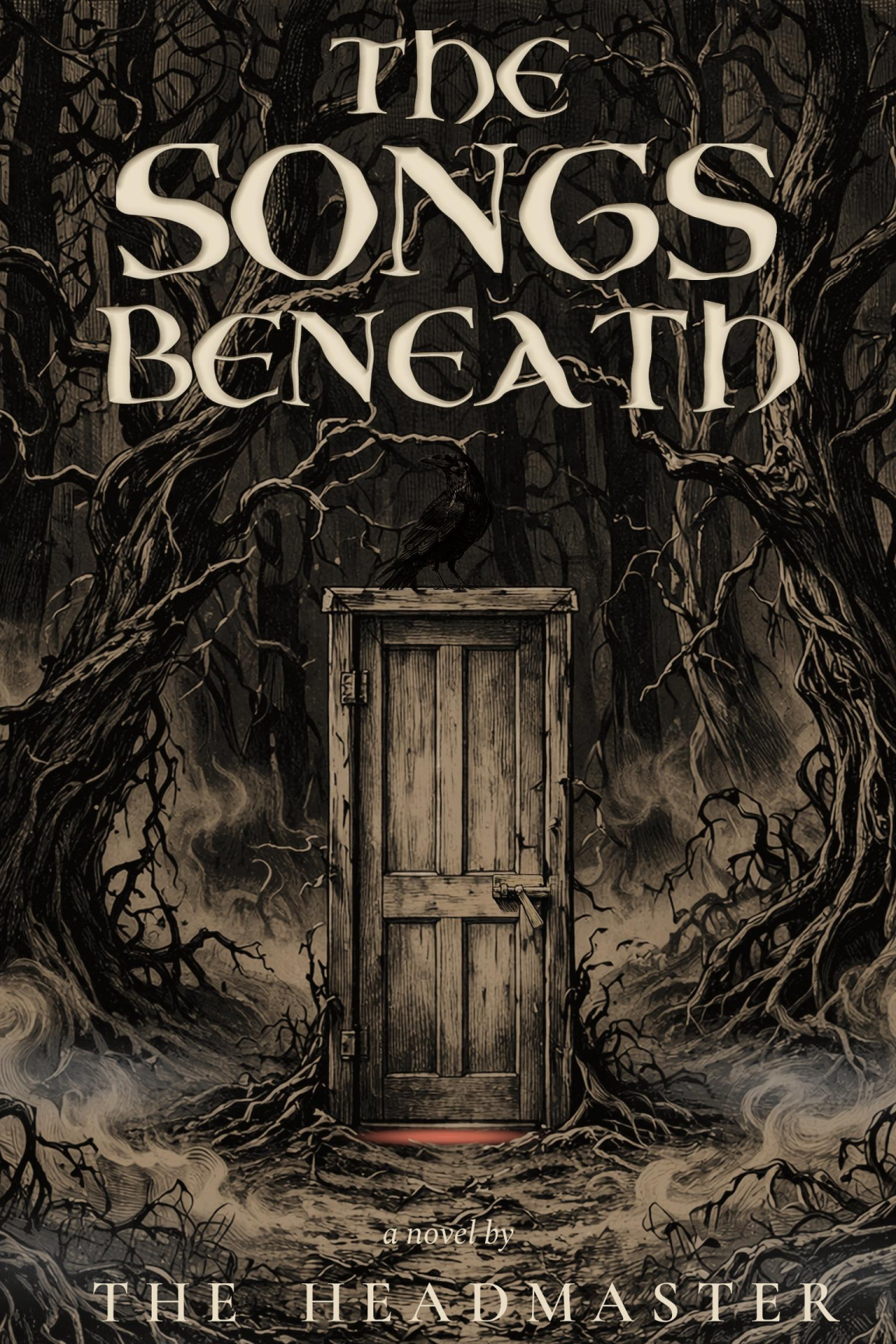
THE SONGS BENEATH



a novel by

THE HEADMASTER

THE SONGS BENEATH

THE SONGS BENEATH

A NOVEL

THE HEADMASTER OF MONTAVERA

MONTAVERA PRESS

TEASER EDITION

THE SONGS BENEATH

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PROLOGUE

The Whispering Door

The door whispered to her for seven months. Tonight she ran up Sollen's Spine to answer it.

The steps were cut into the side of the mountain, more than she could count, worn into hollows by feet that had climbed them long before hers. She took them two at a time until her legs burned. Then one at a time. Then one at a time with her hand on the rock. Snow on every step. Ice beneath it. The wind came up behind her and pushed at her back.

The smell of old smoke and wet stone reached her before she could see the shrine. A cold scent, aging a hundred years. And under all of it, tea. Green and hot and sweet, as the elder women of the tribe used to make when she was a child.

But… Up here? In the dead of winter?

On the side of a mountain, where no one lived?

The wind came up the stairs. The rock under her boots changed. The rough mountain steps gave way to laid stone, smooth and square, fitted so tight no snow could get between them. And the stair didn't end. It ran straight on, up, into the shrine itself.

She stopped on the last open landing with one hand gripping the cord at her chest. With her other hand on her belly, she heaved. Her breath — swirling white rags carried off by the icy wind.

Below her, the mountain fell away into the dark. And beyond it, past the foot of the mountain, spread out under the stars as far as she could see, lay the dead city.

She had never seen it from above.

Nobody she'd ever known had.

Roofs, black. Towers, black. Streets so wide a whole village could have stood across them, running straight as spear shafts for miles, and every one of them empty. Not one fire. Not one lamp. The snow lay on all of it smooth and blue and untouched, like white dust on a grave nobody visits.

She listened, because she always listened. And under the wind, under the hiss of the snow, so low she had to hold her breath to hear it, the dead city had a song.

Old.

Slow.

Slower than anything living, like water moving under a mile of ice. It had been going for longer than anyone's grandmother could remember, and nobody had been left to hear it.

She turned her back on it.

. . .

Above her, the shrine stood against the sky, long and low and old, its roof heavy with snow. At its west end, a tower rose off by itself. Dark from top to bottom. Not one window lit.

She heard them before she saw them. Ravens were perched on the roof. Their harsh grating kraa ripped through the wind and echoed through the spires. Hundreds of them. Shifting their feet, ruffling their feathers, angrily shoving each other. They covered the whole ridge of the roof from one end to the other, black on the white snow, packed shoulder to shoulder like people at a burning. And every one of them was facing the same way.

West. Toward the tower.

She climbed the last flight beneath them in a hurry, her neck prickling under her hood, their presence heavy over her head. Never once did they meet her eyes.

Inside, the stair kept going. Up through the dark, wide and shallow, into the belly of the building. At the top, through an archway, were the front halls, and a light burned there. Gold. Slow. Moving like honey in a swirling jar. It was the only light in such a dark world, and it was beautiful, and it tugged at her — her feet inching towards it — her knees aching with indecision.

She went the other way. Through a side room, cold and bare, to a narrow stair that wound up into the tower.

West — into the shadow.

She kept climbing.

. . .

At the top of the tower stair, the door into the west wing stood open.

She stopped in front of it.

Inside was a corridor, long and straight and dark. Somewhere far down it, the roof had come in. She could see the shape of it, a great slope of broken stone and beams, and out of the gaps in the rubble came a light.

Not gold. Not firelight. Not moonlight. A thin, colorless light, cold as the inside of a spring, coming from nowhere. From nothing. There was no fire under that stone. There was nothing under that stone at all.

And all along the corridor, on both sides, against the walls, were cups.

Little clay cups. Dozens of them. Hundreds. In rows, set out as if for guests. She bent and looked at the nearest one. It was full to the brim. Steam was rising off it, curling, gold-green in that colorless light.

She looked down the row. Steam rose off every one. Every one but the last, at the very end, nearest the dark. That one stood empty.

Somebody had brought them. *Somebody* had carried them all the way up the stair and walked down this corridor — as

far as they dared — and set them down against the wall, and left.

Hundreds of somebodies. Over who knew how many years. And yet. The tea was still hot.

She didn't touch it. She didn't let herself wonder whether the last ones to set them down had gone back home.

She stepped into the corridor.

The cold changed.

It wasn't the clean, biting cold of the mountain. It was older. It lay against her like wet cloth.

And the whispering, which had been in her ears for seven months, which had been under every sound in her life since the morning she first knew she was carrying him, came up to meet her.

. . .

It had started as nothing. A little hiss at the edge of hearing, like snow sliding off a branch somewhere far away. She was a seer. But she learned quickly that to see clearly, she had to listen.

She heard the off-key music *in* the sick since she was a girl, the wrong notes of a fever, the long slow song of an old woman dying. To her, it was as normal as a bird's chirp, as the running of the river, and the dance of a flame. It was just one more thing to hear.

Then it got louder at night. It came when the fire was down and her man was asleep and the village was quiet. It came up through the floor of the house and through the ground and through the soles of her feet, and it wasn't words,

not then. Just whispering. Patient. Polite. The sound a guest makes, waiting outside a door, too courteous to knock.

And every time it came, the child inside her turned toward it.

That was what had brought her here. Not the whispering. She could have lived with the whispering. It was how her son turned in the dark, slowly, under her hand, the way a flower turns toward a window. Toward the sound. Toward the west. Night after night after night.

She walked down the corridor between the steaming cups.

The light in the rubble grew. The cold grew. The whispering grew, until it was all around her, in the walls, in the stones under her boots, and in her teeth. Then the corridor turned, and she came around the corner, and there it was.

The door.

She had thought it would be something terrible. She had imagined it, lying awake. Black iron. Bones. Some great carved mouth.

It was an ordinary door. Wood. Dark with age. A plain wooden latch. The kind of door that hung on every house in her village. It stood at the end of the corridor, set into the old stone wall, and around its edges, in the cracks between the wood and the stone, the darkness was blacker than anything she had ever seen.

Thick. Not empty. Full.

But on the other side of it, something moved.

First it was slow and heavy, like a body dragged across stone. Then it was a great many shifting feathers, the clicking beaks of a thousand ravens. And slowly, the sounds began to settle, drawing together into one — until behind the whole

length of the door there was only one breathing, slow, and it was waiting for her.

Then the whispering stopped.

She stood, listening to the silence it left, her heart beating hard in her throat. "Ma-a-a-a…"

She froze, and the cold crawled into her sleeves.

Her feet moved back without her thinking. Her hand moved over her belly again protectively, but her son turned slowly. Curious. Then, from the other side of the ordinary wooden door, a voice came again.

"Mama."

. . .

She had never heard it in her life and yet… She knew it.

It was a man's voice, young, deep, a little rough at the edges, and she knew it as she knew her own hands. Her breath stopped. Her eyes welled up. Her whole body went loose. Weak.

If anyone you love ever calls you from the dark, her grandmother used to say by the fire, *You don't answer, Child. The dead never call. And the living… They don't call from there.*

"Mama," said the voice. Warm. Gentle. A little tired. Like a grown son coming in from a long day of work. "It's cold out there. You came all this way. Come in."

Her mouth was dry.

Her hands shaking.

She didn't answer.

"I know," the voice said. "I know. I'm sorry. I didn't mean to frighten you. I only wanted you to hear how he'll sound." A pause. Soft. "He's going to have such a beautiful voice."

"Stop it," she said, gritting her teeth. In her belly, the child kicked.

She pressed her hand down hard over him, as if she could cover him, as if she could put her hand over his ears from the outside.

"You're not him."

The words came out of her before she could stop them. She heard them go into the dark. She heard her grandmother's voice by the fire, in memory. Too late.

"No," the voice agreed. "Not yet."

Then, from behind the wood, a different voice.

"Mama?"

A boy. High and thin. A child's voice, hardly older than the little ones who sat at the front of the fire for stories. But wrong. The pitch was a child's and nothing else was. It came too slowly, too carefully, every sound set down in its place, the patience of something very old pressed into a mouth too small for it. Like a man's hand working a child's mitten from the inside.

The grown voice came back. Mild. Interested. The voice of a neighbor holding out a spoon and asking whether the soup wants salt.

"Closer?"

Everything in her rose up to say *no.*

No, he would never sound like that, never, not her boy. It was wrong.

But she clenched her teeth because every word she gave it, it would learn from.

She said nothing. It was the hardest nothing she had ever said.

The many small sounds behind the door shifted. Settled.

"What do you want with him?" Her voice was shaking. She hated it. She made it stop. "What do you want?"

The voice was quiet for a long time. When it spoke again, it had changed. Still courteous. Still kind. But under the kindness, for the first time, something enormous. Something that had been waiting so long, it had forgotten how to be anything else.

"A place," it said. "That's all. That's all I have ever wanted. Somewhere that belongs to me." A breath, on the other side of the wood. "You understand that. Everyone understands that. Everyone wants somewhere to sit by the fire."

"There's nothing out here for you," she said. "It's all dead. Look at it."

"I have," said the voice. "For a very long time."

The cold pressed against her.

"Your boy is going to hear everything," the voice went on, gently. Savoring the moment.

"You know that already," it said. "That's why you're frightened. He's going to hear the music in the sick, the way you do. In the trees. In the stones. In the people he loves. More than you ever could. More than anyone has in a very long while." Something in it warmed, like a grandfather talking about a favorite grandchild. "And one day he's going to hear me."

"No."

She stepped forward, steeling herself.

"No!"

"Oh, but he will," it said. "They always come to the door in the end, the ones who listen. They can't help it. And he's going to be so kind. That's the part I'm looking forward to. He's going to be so very kind."

The voice dropped almost to a whisper. "He's going to open it for me. Not because I make him. Because he'll want to."

She stood there.

She thought about turning around. About walking back out between the cups and the ravens. Back down the long staircase. Back to the road. All the way back home. She'd forget this. This place. She'd lie down beside her man in the dark, pretending she had never come.

The child turned under her hand. Toward the door.

She lifted the flute from her chest.

. . .

It was old, smoothed by the generations of hands who held it, and on its side was carved a single open eye. Her mother's. Her mother's mother's. It had never left the cord around her neck since the day it was given to her, and she had played it over a hundred sickbeds, and she had never, not once, played it as she played it now.

She did not play for the door.

She turned her shoulder to the door, as you turn your shoulder to a wind, and bent her head, and put the flute to her

lips, and played down. Down, toward her own belly. Toward him.

It was hardly a song. Three notes, going round. The little thing she had hummed to him every night since she first knew he was there, lying with her hand on her belly in the dark. She played it low. She played it slow. And as she played, she listened, as she had been taught to listen, to the music under her hand.

He had a music already. Of course he did. Small and new and bright as a spark, the music of somebody who did not exist yet and already did. She had been hearing it for months. She could hear it now, under the notes. Turning. Turning toward the door.

She played her three notes around it.

Around and around. Like a blanket. Like a hand cupped around a candle in the wind. She played until her lips went numb and her breath ran short and her fingers ached on the cold holes, and with every turn of the song, his music grew quieter. Quieter. Tucked away. Wrapped up. Smaller and smaller, until it was only a spark in a cupped hand, and then less than a spark, and then—

Nothing.

She stopped playing.

She stood in the cold corridor with the flute against her lips and listened to her own body, and there was nothing there. No music. No little bright turning thing. Silence, under her hand, where her son had been.

Her breath went out of her in a sound she had never made before.

What did I do. What did I do?!

And under her hand, against her palm, small and hard and furious, he kicked.

She folded over him. She held her belly in both arms with the flute crushed between them, and she shook. The tears ran down her face and froze on her cheeks, and he kicked again.

Alive. Alive. Alive, and quiet, and hidden, and hers.

"What are you doing?" said the voice from behind the wooden door.

She didn't answer.

A long silence. The many small sounds had stopped moving. Something felt different. A quiet like danger. Like eyes looking down on prey.

"Where did he go?"

For the first time, the courtesy slipped. Only a little. Only for a breath. And in that breath she heard, under the kindness, under the patience, under the gentle tired voice of her grown son, how very old the thing behind the door was. How old, and how hungry, and how alone.

Then it was gone, and the voice was warm again.

"Ah," it said. "That's a lovely thing you've done. It really is."

It sounded almost proud of her. "It won't hold, you know. Nothing holds forever. Not songs. Not mothers."

A pause.

"I'm very good at waiting," it said. A whisper. Soft. Gentle. Smiling.

She straightened up, hung the flute back on its cord, wiped her face with the back of her mitten, and turned around, walking away from the door.

She did not run. She would not give it that. She walked down the corridor between the hundreds of steaming cups, under the cold light. Down the tower stair, round and round in the dark. Through the side room. Past the gold light in the front halls without once turning her head. Down the shrine's long flight and out into the snow and the wind, under the ravens. They did not turn to watch her go. They never took their eyes off the west, where the wooden door waited.

On the last open landing, where the laid stone gave way to the mountain, she stopped once, with her hand on her belly, and looked out at the dead city lying under the stars.

Then she started down and the voice called after her.

At the top of the mountain stair, it was the grown man. Warm. Tired. A voice she would never live to hear for herself. A song like the river under ice.

Mama.

She didn't answer. She kept climbing down.

A hundred steps later, where the stair bent around the shoulder of the mountain, it came again. Younger. A young man's voice, still finding its depth, a little too loud, like young men who want you to know they're there.

Mama.

Lower. The wind came up the stair and pushed at her face, and through it, down from the dark above, came a boy's voice cracking in the middle, high and then low and then high again, the year a voice can't decide what it is.

Mama?

She walked faster. She did not run.

Lower. A child. Seven, perhaps. Out of breath, as if he'd been running to catch up to her, and cross with her for not waiting.

Mama. Mama, wait.

Her eyes ran and froze. She did not wait. She did not turn her head.

Near the bottom, where the stone steps gave out into the snow and the mountain let her go, it came one last time.

Small. So small. Two soft sounds, not quite steady, as a word comes out the first time a mouth has ever made it.

Ma-ma.

And it was right.

She knew it was right. She had been hearing his music for seven months, every night, under her hand. This was the voice that music would grow into. The voice that would call her from the next room. From the yard, with his knees muddy. From his bed in the dark when he woke up frightened and didn't know where he was. It made her sick to admit it. It had found him.

In the time it took her to walk down a mountain, it had learned to be her son.

She put both hands over her belly and stood in the snow at the foot of the stair, shaking. Under her hands he was quiet. Hidden. Hers.

She did not answer.

She walked on into the dark toward home, and did not look back, and behind her, far up the mountain in the west wing, the voice said the word once more. Softly. To itself.

Perfectly.



CHAPTER ONE

Son of Gennady

Wind blew carrying the smell of dirt, wet wood, and chipped iron. A pair of old leather gloves lay in a bucket next to rusted shovels. Something acrid and cold like a rotting mist lingered, growing worse with each new grave.

Tomek stood between the two mounds. Three nights and the snow still hadn't fully covered them. Every time it tried, the wind came across the field and scraped them bare, and the raw dirt showed through, dark as a wound.

His shoulders sagged, one carrying the weight of a red sack. Everything he owned that he could carry was in it. Flint. Dried meat. His canteen. The quick shelter, rolled tight.

His mother's old wool scarf was wound twice around his neck and pulled up over his mouth. It still smelled a little of smoke and pine and of story time by the fire whenever he breathed in through it.

His mother's grave was almost a year old. The dirt was smooth and settled, rounded at the edges. His father's didn't belong anywhere yet. The warriors dug it out of the frozen ground with bent and weathered picks, taking turns to dig.

Tomek had watched them, a knot in his throat. Not one of them said a word the entire time except to say whose turn it was. *Chunk.* A long breath. *Chunk.* Like somebody knocking on a door that wasn't going to open.

He hadn't come to cry. He'd done enough of that. He was here to speak with his parents. One last time.

His hand found the knife at his belt. His father's hunting knife. The leather on the handle had been worn dark and smooth by a bigger hand than his, and his fingers didn't fit the grooves. They sat in them like a child's feet in a man's boots. Three nights ago, in the hut, with the fire down to coals and the smell of the sickness so thick it coated the back of his tongue, his father had pressed that handle into his palm. His father's hand had been hot. Hotter than anything alive should be. The black tears had already run down into his beard, dried there in streaks, with more coming, but his father hadn't wiped them because he'd needed both hands to hold Tomek's.

He'd closed Tomek's fingers around the handle, one at a time. Then he'd held them there.

Protect them. All of them. Promise me.

Tomek had promised.

The weakness had all but drained the old warrior, and the fever had burned away his strength. The black tears — they were the final sign — he didn't have long to live. Even children knew the symptoms. They chanted them in their clapping games, until their mothers slapped their hands for it.

The weakness will take you,
The fever brings fear,
And doomed are the ones
who show the black tears

Tomek pulled the knife an inch out of its sheath and pushed it back. The sound it made was small and clean in the cold.

"I'm going," he told the graves.

Nobody answered. That was fine. He hadn't come for an answer.

He turned his back on them and walked into the village.

. . .

He took the long way — the path between the huts, on the side away from the fires, keeping to the shadows where the snow was packed hard and didn't creak.

The village had gone quiet in a way he had never experienced. A goat complained in the pen, a sharp grumble piercing through the wind. Somebody coughed inside a hut, and the cough went on too long, and someone cried, and the

cough stopped, and in the quiet afterward Tomek could almost hear every other hut holding its breath to listen.

That was how it was now. Everybody listened to everybody's coughs.

They *used* to listen to him, around the campfire, imitating old Petra's griping, imitating the goats, imitating the elders arguing, and last of all, imitating his father's laugh, the big one. They used to laugh, his father most of all. As of late, nobody had asked him to imitate anything. Not since the burial.

He didn't think anybody would again.

If they *did* speak, they did it in whispers, guarding their breath. Mothers kept their children inside. The warriors sat by the fires with their knives across their knees and watched the tree line, as if the darkness were something that might come walking out of the woods on four legs. And every morning, without anybody ever saying a word about it, people checked each other's eyes. Over the porridge. Over the woodpile. A look, a little too long, at the corners. Then away.

He'd caught Maari doing it to him, the morning after the burial. She hadn't even pretended she wasn't.

He passed her hut now. Dark. He walked faster.

Past the last of the huts was the burning place, and he had to pass that too. He pulled the scarf up over his nose. Dead kerzit, heaped up and set alight whenever the warriors brought them in, and the smoke of them was the worst smell in the world. Sweet and sour together. Meat that had frozen and thawed and frozen again.

The elders claimed the kerzit crawled out from pits of hell to bring pain to the living. A kerzit bite caused the disease –

the darkness. Once in a household, the darkness spread like cancer, cruel and indifferent, like a guest nobody could turn away.

The storm was just weather. The kerzit were the real winter.

And there was only one cure. Far off, at the top of Sollen's Spine, in a shrine as old as legend, a guru kept a font of Aria — the only known substance that could heal the darkness.

Tomek had been to the foot of the Spine every summer of his life.

The whole village went. They walked for weeks taking goats and gifts, the elders riding on sledges, and at the bottom of the mountain, where the path turned to stone steps that went up into the clouds, they left what they'd carried. Bread. Furs. Carved things. They did it to remind the guru that the people still remembered him. Still prayed. Still needed him.

The best was when his mother played her kalyuka there, every year, standing on the bottom step with her face turned up the mountain. The whole crowd would go silent to listen. It was a rare gift to hear her play. Most of the time, she was gone far away. When word came of a fever in some other village, she wrapped it in its cloth and went, a week, two weeks, to whoever was sick, to sit by them and play. It was healing music, but afterwards, she always came home thin. She'd sleep a whole day, and then she'd get up and make porridge as if she'd never been gone.

She had to be careful with the kalyuka, playing it sparingly, only when it was truly necessary. Everyone knew, so

when she played it at the Spine, at the base of the steps, no one spoke. Even the goats stopped chewing.

Nobody actually climbed the steps in summer. The journey there was its own reward. Children learned from the elders' stories. Families mingled and sang songs and danced. The little ones learned to hunt in the woods. The bigger ones learned to trade in the many villages they crossed. It was an annual rite that helped the tribe grow as a people.

Only the elders ever went up the steps, and they did so in the spring. Four or five of them, and a half a dozen hunters, made the trip. With the gifts on their backs, by some other road, they went and came, and when they came home, they brought it back with them — A clay pot no bigger than a fist, sealed with wax, filled with that precious golden liquid. It lived on the high shelf in the elders' hut and was brought down only for the worst bites.

One drop at a time, they would say. Tomek had only seen it opened twice in his life. But that all changed two springs ago.

The elders went, the best of the warriors with them, his father leading the pack, and his mother with her kalyuka on its cord. But this time they returned early. Far too early.

They came home with their wounded on sledges. One of the elders didn't make it back at all. And what's worse — there was no jar. Not a single drop of Aria.

After that, the last of the tribe's supply was used to treat Petra's boy, who'd been bitten on the way back, but even that wasn't enough. The boy didn't make it.

Last spring, nobody went, and nobody told the children why, so when his father came in from the woods this winter with a kerzit bite on the back of his hand, already tired,

already slow on the path, the jar on the high shelf was dry. Empty as death.

Tomek bent down and pushed his hand into the grave, letting his finger sink into the snow. He looked up, north. Far, far north was the guru in his shrine. He was supposed to take care of his people. He was supposed to keep these things from happening. That's what the children were always told.

The guru is our protector.

Lately, it seemed the guru needed more reminding.

Tomek would remind him.

He would climb the Spine and come home with enough Aria to heal the tribe ten times over. And then they would have to look at him. All of them. The warriors who'd never once let him hunt. The old women who patted his head in passing like he was one of the goats. Maari, who looked at him like a crack in a pot, deciding whether it was worth mending. They would have to look at him and see what his father had seen.

He could see it already. The ridge north of the village at dusk, and the whole tribe out in the snow to meet him. He knew exactly how that sounded, because he had heard it every winter of his life from the top rail of the fence. First one voice, some kid with sharp eyes. Then all of them. The shouting going up and up, and the little ones running out across the field to meet the line of men coming down the ridge with the kill slung between them. And at the front of the line, always at the front, his father. Snow in his beard. A carcass across his shoulders like it weighed nothing. Laughing.

Not the small laugh. The big one. The one that came out of him so seldom that the whole village stopped to look when it did.

Next winter, his father had said, every time Tomek asked to go out with them. *Next winter.* And over Tomek's head, every time, his mother had looked at his father, and his father had looked away.

There were no more next winters.

He reached the fence. The gap where the goats used to get out was still there. His father had been meaning to fix it for three summers.

Tomek put his hand on the post and looked back once at the dark huts, and the one red fire, and the shape of a warrior sitting by it with his head nodding.

No one could know. Not until it was too late for them to stop him.

He went through the gap. The snow swallowed his footprints almost as fast as he made them.

Nobody needed to show him the way. Every village knew the way to Sollen's Spine. A week, if all went well. Less, without stopping. He had never climbed the mountain, and nobody climbed it in winter. But his father used to say the climb is only as hard as you are weak in heart.

Tomek wasn't weak in heart.

So the climb would not be hard.

. . .

The first day, he walked until his legs shook.

The second day, he walked until they stopped shaking and just went numb, which was worse.

In the open places the snow came to his knees. In the drifts it came to his waist, and he had to swim through it, more or less, shoving it aside with his arms while the wind threw more of it into his face. His lips split. He licked them and they split worse. His fingers stopped bending, and when he cupped his hands over his mouth and breathed into them, the warmth lasted a second, maybe two, and then it was gone, and his hands were colder than before for having had it.

There was a tune in his head the whole way. Where it came from, he had no idea. It had always been there, as long as he could remember, like knowing how to swallow. It wasn't even a whole tune. Three notes, going round. His boots fell into it without asking him. Three steps. Three notes. Round again.

By the second night, he was close to Lenka's Weald.

He saw it from the top of a ridge. A long black line of trees laid across the white, so thick and so dark that the snow didn't seem to fall into it so much as disappear.

His mother used to tell stories about the Weald by the fire, and she always told them in a lower voice than her other stories, and she never finished them the same way twice. Nobody went in. Nobody went near it, if they could help it. In one telling, a girl went in after her brother and brought him out again. In another, neither of them came out at all. Tomek had asked which one was true, once, and his mother had looked at him over the fire, and kept looking, and said, *Both, I should think.*

He would have to pass it tomorrow. Along the edge. Not in. Along.

After a difficult trek down the side of the ridge, Tomek found a big fallen tree. It had gone hollow. He stopped there because his legs stopped there. Inside the trunk, curled together in a nest of dead leaves, was a family of little brown critters. Four of them. Maybe five. It was hard to tell where one ended and the next began. They were packed so tight their breaths came out together, one small cloud, going up and fading and going up again.

They didn't run. They just watched him, too cold to move.

He found he was counting their breaths. He hadn't meant to. One. Two. Three. There was a rhythm to it. He found it curious that with five of them in there, only one cloud rose and faded on every count, as if they breathed with one chest. His own cloud was bigger, and there was only one of him.

He rigged his quick shelter in the lee of the trunk, where the wind couldn't get at him quite so easily. His fingers, frozen and stiff, fumbled the knots twice. The third time, they remembered. His father had taught him to rig it the summer he turned eight. He remembered kneeling in the grass behind the hut, while his father's big fingers deftly showed him the knots.

So you've always got a roof, his father had said. *Wherever you are.*

Tomek crawled inside the bark and pulled his knees up to his chest, his mother's scarf wrapped tight over his nose, and through it all, three notes went round and round in his head, and he was asleep before he had decided to be.

He dreamed about his mother's hands. About his father's laugh, the big one.

. . .

He woke when the wind changed.

It was the only sound in the world. It came off the Weald in long, slow pushes and leaned on the walls of the shelter. It leaned and let go, and the cloth breathed in and out over his face. Through it, the dark outside was a deeper dark. No moon.

Then, in the wind, his name.

Tomek.

Far off. Thin. Pulled long by the gusts so that he couldn't have said if it was high or low, a man or a woman, near the trees or out on the open snow. Only that it was his name, and that it came from out there, from the dark.

Every hair on his arms stood up under his sleeves.

He knew the rule. Every child in the village knew the rule. The old women told it at the fire on long nights, and the mothers told it at bedtime,

If anyone you love ever calls you from the dark, they said, *You don't answer. The dead don't call. And the living don't call from there.*

If anyone you love ever calls you from the dark, they would say, *You don't answer. The dead never call. And the living… They don't call from there.*

Several years ago, his mother had been tucking the fur up under his chin.

But why? he said.

Her hands stopped.

That's the rule, she'd said as she finished tucking the fur. She said nothing else, but he remembered staying awake that night watching her. She didn't speak that night. She just sat. Watching the door.

Tomek.

The voice was closer this time. Too close. Or the wind was louder. There was no telling.

He bit down on his scarf, wool and spit and the old smell of smoke filled his gums. He pressed himself flat to the ground. His heart was going so hard he could feel it in the snow under him.

He didn't answer.

He thought of his father's hand, the day they last spoke. Once so strong, but in the end weak and hot as a coal.

Tomek.

It was here. That was no wind. But he wouldn't answer the voice. He thought of his mother on the bottom step of the Spine, every summer, and the whole crowd going silent.

He held his breath until his chest burned.

Nothing.

The wind leaned on the shelter. Let go.

He let his breath out a little at a time, into the scarf, so it wouldn't make a cloud.

That's when the shelter came apart.

. . .

The walls tore away all at once. The cold rushed in like water. Something grabbed him by the front of his coat and hauled

him straight up off the ground, and his heart tried to come out through his throat.

"Let me go!" He swung his fists. He kicked. He clawed at the arm that had him. "*Let me go!*"

It took him a few seconds to understand that nothing was eating him. Not a bear. Not a kerzit.

"Tomek!"

Maari.

With a single hand, she lifted him off the ground and held him there, her eyes tired. Annoyed. She waited for him to stop kicking, then set him down on his feet and caught his wrist. Her grip was terrible. He felt the small bones of his wrist grind together. And even through her mitten, through his sleeve, her hand was hot.

"I called you several times," she said.

Tomek stared at her. Snow was blowing between them. His breath came in ragged clouds that the wind tore away.

"You're supposed to answer when someone calls you."

He couldn't answer her. He tried. He opened his mouth but… nothing came out, so he shut it again.

She towered over him, waiting. In what little light there was, he could see the scar that ran through her left eyebrow, splitting it in two, and her strong bright eyes peering into him as they had the morning after the burial.

A bead of sweat trickled down from her temple and her cheeks were flushed.

"You can't stay here," she said. She let go of his wrist. "Follow me. Don't fall behind."

She turned and walked off into the dark without looking to see if he would.

Tomek stood there with the snow going down his collar and his wrist throbbing where she'd held it. His shelter lay in the snow at his feet, the cloth torn half off its lines, flapping. His father's knots, still tied. The cloth ripped right out of them.

He was too rattled to argue. Too much in shock to do anything but kneel, gather the torn shelter into his arms, stuff it into his sack, and follow her.

. . .

She was taking him back.

Every bone in his body knew it. She was going to march him back to the village, empty-handed, so everyone could see. The boy who ran off in the night to save everybody and didn't even make it past the Weald. They'd come out of the huts to look, the way they came out for the hunters. Only nobody would cheer.

And Maari would walk in front. The way his father used to.

His father used to call her the best of them. Right in front of Tomek. At the fire, with the other warriors around him, he'd say it as plain as he'd say the weather. *Maari is the best of us.* And the other warriors would nod, and Maari would look into the flames as if she hadn't heard.

But his father had given *Tomek* the knife. Not her. His father had made *Tomek* promise to protect the tribe. Not her. Whatever he'd said at the fire, that was what he'd meant in the end. Tomek was sure of it, and he wasn't about to let her ruin it.

His right hand drifted to his belt. His fingers found the leather of the handle.

He would never actually *hurt* her. He knew that. But he had to say something. He had to make her see. He was the son of Gennady, and if anybody was going to save the tribe it should be him, because that was what his father wanted.

He had never found it easy to talk to Maari. It wasn't fear. He wasn't scared of her. It was that his father had respected her so much, and out of respect for his father, Tomek held back from telling her what he truly thought about her.

But things were different now.

Things *had* to be different now.

He walked behind her for nearly an hour, working himself up to it. Every step, a little more. His heart beat faster. His face went hot inside the scarf, despite the cold. His breath dampened the wool and it froze stiff against his mouth.

Then he ripped the knife out of his belt and let out a battle cry.

It came out higher than he wanted.

Maari spun around.

For half a heartbeat her eyes went wide, seeing him there with the blade up between them. Then they narrowed again.

"What do you think you're doing?" she said.

There was no fear in it at all. It was the voice she used on the little kids when they climbed the meat racks.

His hand was shaking, and it wouldn't stop. His arm had gone heavy all at once. Suddenly the knife weighed as much as a log. But he wouldn't lower it.

"I'm not going back, Maari." He raised the blade higher and pointed the tip at her. "I won't. I have to reach the shrine. I have to be the one to bring back the—"

"You *have* to do nothing of the sort." She took a step toward him.

A knot caught in his throat. His gut went tight. He fell back a step. Then another.

But he didn't lower the knife.

She looked at the blade. Then at him. The corners of her mouth curled, very slightly.

"Are you going to hurt me, Tomek?" she said.

She didn't even take a stance. She just stood there with her arms loose at her sides and the snow settling on her shoulders. Didn't she respect him? Not even a little? Did she want to humiliate him so badly?

"I don't want to," said Tomek. "But I'll do what I have to. For my people."

"Your people," she said.

She reached behind her back and drew her own knife. The same as his. The same dark wood, the same leather on the handle, the same long curve of the blade. Every warrior of the tribe carried one.

"These are not for using on *your* people, boy," she said. "And as for your little quest to the shrine, that was never your decision to make. We would never have sent you alone. You're not ready. You're a boy. You can't—"

"*I can!*"

Tomek lunged.

He swung at her arm. Not hard. Not to hurt her. Just enough to scare her. Just enough to make her see him.

His hesitation wasn't lost on her. She saw it coming from a mile away.

She didn't move.

She let the blade find her shoulder. It barely went in. It caught through the fur of her coat and found skin, and that was all, and in the same instant it touched her she had him. Her hands were on his waist, and the sky swung over. His feet went out from under him and his face went down.

Snow was in his mouth. It was up his nose. It had gone down the front of his coat and was melting against his belly, and somewhere out of sight, his father's knife lay in a drift where it had flown out of his hand. He lay there and breathed snow. It tasted like nothing. It tasted like cold.

"You have no technique," said Maari.

She was standing over him. He could hear it in her voice, how far above him she was.

"I could have put my blade in your gut a dozen different ways, and there's not a thing you could have done to stop me."

A pause.

"But you knew that. Didn't you."

He couldn't look up. He couldn't let her see his eyes. They were burning, and it wasn't the cold, and if she saw them he would die. He would die right there, face down in the snow, and they would have to come out from the village and dig him a grave beside his father's, and the picks would go *chunk* and *chunk*, and nobody would say a word except whose turn it was.

Why couldn't she just let him go?

"We don't have time for this," she said. She stepped over him. "If you're done with your tantrum, we need to move. The

storm's getting worse. Anton and Yana are in a cave not far from here. We'll wait it out there."

She said the second name with weight. She spoke it as if it weighed something, and she had to set it down carefully.

Tomek lifted his face out of the snow.

"Yana?" he said. "She's a baby. She's not even eight. Why is she out here? Why didn't you leave her back with the tribe?"

Maari didn't answer. She walked on into the white. And down her left arm, from the shoulder he'd touched, one thin line of red ran and gathered at the ends of her fingers, dripping into the snow. One drop then another.

. . .

Tomek found the knife half buried in a drift. He wiped it on his trousers and put it back in his belt. His hand was still shaking so he made a fist to make it stop.

He took one last look across the plain, at the path he should have been on. The road to the shrine. It ran off into the storm, white on white, and then it was gone.

When he turned back to follow Maari, he saw it — Mount Amana.

He knew the mountain. Everybody knew that mountain. Its peak was split down the middle, like some giant had struck it with an axe. On clear days you could see it from the village, far to the west. The elders would point at it and say nothing at all.

He hurried to catch up.

"Why are we going west?" he said.

"The cave's this way," she said, without looking at him.

"That's Mount Amana. The village is south. If we go this way it'll take longer to get—"

"We're not going back to the village."

Tomek stopped.

"You forced my hand, Tomek," she said. "You've come this far, so we might as well finish it. But the road you were on is a bad road in winter. A very bad road. We go west. Around Lenka's Weald, not along it."

"Wait." He stood in the snow and stared at her back. "You came all the way out here. You tore my shelter apart. You threw me on the ground. And now you're going to the shrine *anyway?*"

She stopped too, then turned and looked at him. Really looked, for the first time since she'd pulled him out of his sleep. And maybe for the first time ever, there was something warm in her eyes. It didn't last. But he saw it.

"You weren't wrong to want to come out here, Tomek," she said. "You were wrong to come alone." She let out a breath, and it turned to ice in the air between them. "Truthfully, you shouldn't have come at all. This is what Gennady trained the warriors for."

"I'm his *son*."

It came out so loud it surprised them both. His words carried off across the snow toward the Weald. The Weald took them and didn't give them back.

"If anybody was going to save the tribe, it should be me. You just want the credit. You always have. You don't understand what it's like to lose—"

"Trust me, Tomek."

She didn't shout. She never shouted. "I understand more than you know."

She looked away from him, over her shoulder, at the hills climbing toward the split mountain. She said nothing at all. The wind pulled her hair loose from under her hood and laid it across her face, and she didn't push it away. She was breathing harder than the walk deserved.

"I have family too," she said, "And I won't let them die. Not this winter. Not to the darkness."

She reached into the leather pouch at her waist, took something out, and held it out to him.

It was a flute. An old one. Pale wood, gone darker at both ends where hands had held it for years and years.

He stared at it, his hands at his sides.

"Take it, boy." She pushed it against his chest. Instinct kicked in and he grabbed it before it fell. "It's time you started practicing."

He held it in both hands.

For a few seconds, all he could do was look. The smooth pale length of it. The finger holes, worn into soft dips by somebody's fingertips, year after year after year. And near the end, carved into the wood, an eye. A single open eye, the lid and the lash and the round of it, cut so cleanly it seemed to look back.

Slowly, he understood what he was holding.

He forgot the knife. He forgot his anger. For one breath, he even forgot his father.

He had seen this every night of his life. He had heard it, by the fire, with the whole village around. On the bottom step of

the Spine, every summer, with the goats gone quiet. In the hut, late, when she thought he was asleep.

"This is my mother's," he said. His voice came out very small. "This is her kalyuka."

Maari nodded.

"Why do you have it?" He ran his thumb over the carved eye. The wood was cold, and then, under his thumb, a little less cold. "Why did *you* have it?"

"Gennady gave it to me," she said. "Not to use. He knew his days were numbered when that damned kerzit bit him. So he gave it to me, and he said she'd wanted you to have it. When you were ready."

"The seer's call," said Tomek. He barely heard himself.

"That's right."

He looked up at her. She was smiling. Not much. A little.

In her smile he saw the same look his father had given him each time he said, *Next winter.*

"That's why you were never trained as a warrior," she said. "You were never meant to take your father's place, Dummy."

She turned and started walking again, toward the split mountain, toward the cave.

"You're meant to be our tribe's next seer."

THE STORY CONTINUES

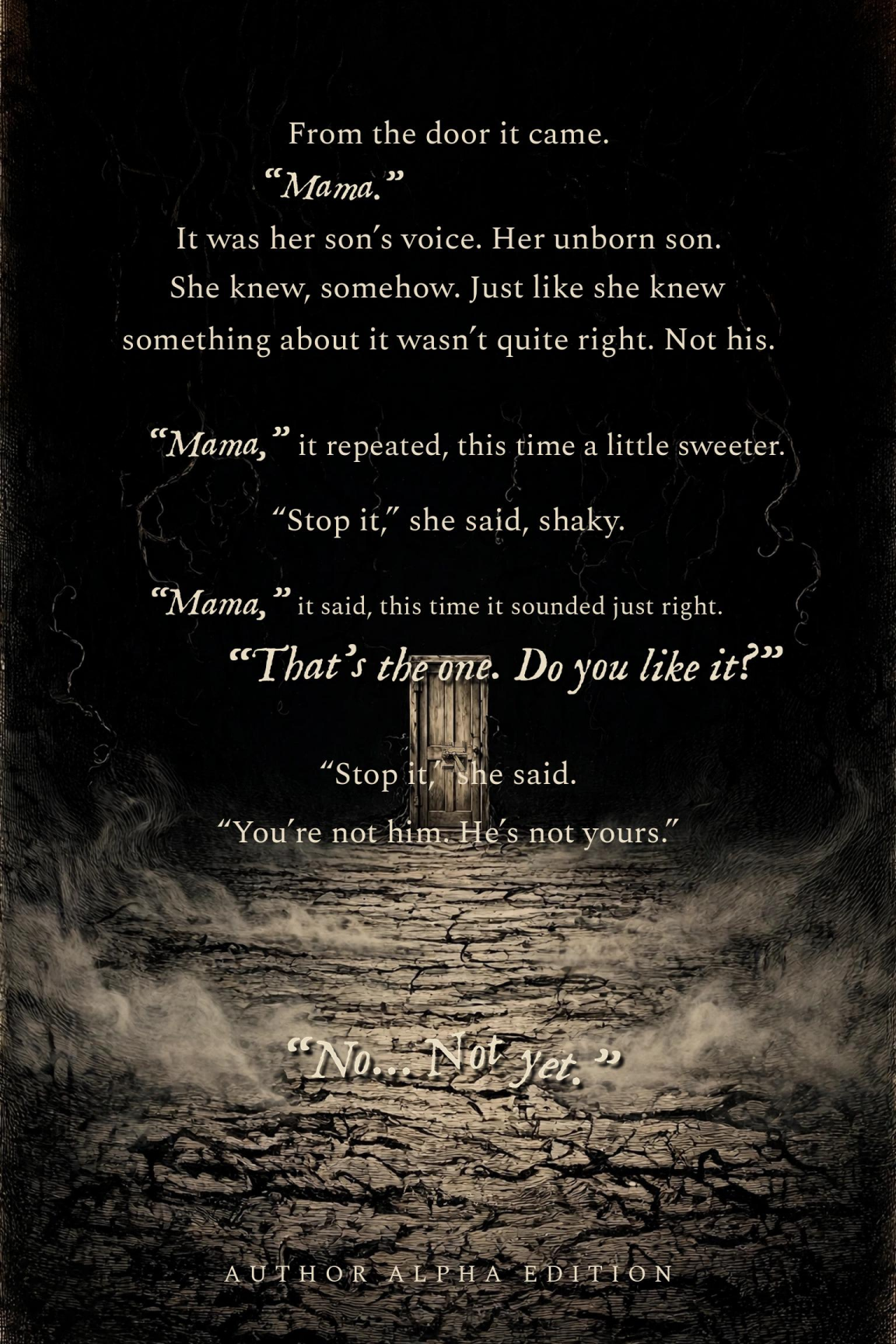
Tomek's story is Book One of Montavera — a world Sebastian Aguilar has built in public for years: a novel, a tabletop setting (The Black Index), and the Factions card game, all growing from one city.

New chapters, lore filings, and launch news are shared first with readers on the list.

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Written by Sebastian Aguilar. Claude served as critique partner, editor, and drafting partner for connective prose — and nothing is finished until the author's own hand has been on it.


From the door it came.
"Mama."
It was her son's voice. Her unborn son.
She knew, somehow. Just like she knew
something about it wasn't quite right. Not his.
"Mama," it repeated, this time a little sweeter.
"Stop it," she said, shaky.
"Mama," it said, this time it sounded just right.
"That's the one. Do you like it?"
"Stop it," she said.
"You're not him. He's not yours."
"No... Not yet."
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